

Panwar topped the tournament wicket charts with 25 scalps in 10 matches, including four in the final, but Saurashtra fell short on the day and finished runner-up.

Vidarbha's success in white-ball cricket also speaks to the team's mindset. As coach Usman Ghani points out, if one game goes wrong, the players bounce back in the next one as a unit. "We are always confident of coming back and that's what we are teaching everyone in the team," Ghani says. That resilience, Ghani believes, has been reinforced by depth within the squad and sustained internal competition. While its domestic treble — the Ranji Trophy, Duleep Trophy and Irani Cup — inspired the players, he feels that the bench strength has kept the environment lively. "We have players waiting to grab the opportunities and they want to capitalise on each outing, and that makes it easy for us to take on challenges," he says.

This was underlined by the fact that despite Dhruv Shorey not playing the final and Danish Malewar missing out on the league phase due to injury, the team still managed to put up a compelling show.

Return of the big names

Beyond Vidarbha's breakthrough, the tournament also carried wider significance for Indian cricket. A short interval in the international calendar allowed national team players to maintain their sharpness by turning up for their States. With competition for places stiffening ahead of the next iteration of the ODI World Cup in 2027, the VHT served as a crucial platform to press claims for spots in the ODI squad. Former captains Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli were greeted by contrasting audiences during their two-match stints in the domestic competition. Rohit was welcomed to the Sawai Mansingh Stadium in Jaipur by a 10,000-strong crowd, who were treated to a 94-ball 155 by the opener, which included his fastest List A hundred. In Bengaluru, by contrast, for the first time in 15 years, a trademark Kohli century was met with sparse applause, with the BCCI Centre of Excellence not welcoming spectators into its campus.



Hitman: Rohit Sharma's fluent hundred in Jaipur was a reminder of his enduring class, even as India's road to the 2027 World Cup sharpens the conversation around ODI continuity and depth. R. V. MOORTHY

There were performances of note from other Indian regulars too. Tilak Varma scored a century in his first match for Hyderabad against Chandigarh, while Sanju Samson recorded his fourth List A hundred for Kerala against Jharkhand. Dhruv Jurel and Devdutt Padikkal produced superlative seasons with the bat, aggregating 558 and 725 runs, respectively, strengthening their claims for ODI consideration. Hardik Pandya flexed his muscles with two stunning blitzes for Baroda and sent a subliminal message to the selectors by bowling his full quota of overs in the contest against Chandigarh.

Shubman Gill's return from injury was delayed due to illness. The Indian Test captain featured in just one match for Punjab and failed to make an impact with the bat. Rishabh Pant endured an unexceptional tournament, scoring just a couple of half-centuries in his seven encounters for Delhi. On the bowling front, pacers Arshdeep Singh, Mohammed Siraj and Prasidh Krishna had impactful cameos before their participation in the ODI series against New Zealand.

Level playing field

If individual performances provided one layer of intrigue, structural tweaks to the playing conditions offered another. The introduction of a rule mandating the



Run-machine: Virat Kohli's domestic hundred came in quiet surroundings in Bengaluru, a familiar milestone set against India's wider reflections on experience, depth and the road to the 2027 World Cup. K. MURALIKUMAR

use of a single ball from overs 35 till the end of the innings helped bring bowlers back into contention at the death. There were only five instances of a side crossing the 400-run mark across the tournament, including the List A record 574 for 6, which Bihar plundered against Arunachal Pradesh in the Plate league.

The four-fielders-outside-the-circle rule across the second PowerPlay, clubbed with the use of two balls in an innings, had previously curtailed the bowlers' ability to force breakthroughs in batting line-ups. The latest change gives faster bowlers, conditions permitting, a chance to utilise some reverse swing late in the innings.

"I have seen our bowlers have been able to reverse the ball a little after the BCCI implemented the new rule. There is some movement they were able to extract in the last 10 overs, which gives them a chance to do something against the batters in the end," observed Bengal spinner Shahbaz Ahmed.

The recent ODI series loss to New Zealand has reopened the debate over a few spots in the Indian playing eleven as the 2027 event draws closer. The 2025-26 VHT suggested that there is adequate potential among domestic performers to step in if the selectors believe a course correction is required.